# Awusah on Leadership

NOTES ON LEADING PEOPLE, TEAMS AND ORGANIZATIONS



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## Meetings That Move Work Forward: A Leader's Guide

— Start with the decision, not the agenda
— Invite the right people, and only them
— Prepare the material in advance

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# Meetings That Move Work Forward: A Leader's Guide

Most teams do not need fewer conversations. They need meetings with a clear purpose, the right people and a decision at the end.

By Dr. Solomon Chukwuemeka Awusah (Non-Clinical Strategist) · November 7, 2026

## Start with the decision, not the agenda

Many meetings begin with a list of topics and end with a vague sense that things were discussed. A better starting point is a single question: what do we need to decide, or learn, by the time this meeting ends? If no one can answer that, the meeting probably is not ready to happen.

Writing the purpose at the top of the invitation does two things. It helps people prepare, and it gives the person running the meeting a clear way to bring a wandering conversation back on track. When the discussion drifts, a leader can simply ask whether the current topic helps answer the question the group came to settle.

## Invite the right people, and only them

Large meetings feel inclusive, but they often slow everything down. Each extra person adds another point of view, another set of questions and another calendar to work around. The goal is to include the people who will make the decision, the people who have information the decision needs, and the people who will carry it out.

Others can be kept informed in writing. A short summary sent afterward respects their time and still keeps them in the loop. Most people appreciate being trusted to read a note instead of sitting through an hour of discussion that only partly concerns them.

## Prepare the material in advance

Meetings lose much of their value when the first twenty minutes are spent explaining background that could have been shared ahead of time. A brief written summary, sent a day before, lets everyone arrive with the same facts and spend the meeting on judgment rather than on catching up.

The summary does not need to be polished. A few paragraphs describing the situation, the options under consideration and the main tradeoffs are usually enough. Leaders who model this habit find that their teams begin to do the same.

## Make room for disagreement

A meeting where everyone agrees quickly is not always a good sign. Sometimes it means people have reservations they are not comfortable raising. Leaders can change this by asking directly for concerns, by inviting quieter members to speak first, and by thanking people who point out problems.

Disagreement handled well makes decisions stronger. It surfaces risks early, when they are still cheap to address, and it gives people confidence that the final choice was tested rather than rubber-stamped.

## Close with owners and dates

The last few minutes of a meeting matter more than the first. Before anyone leaves, the group should confirm what was decided, who is responsible for each next step and when each step is due. Saying it out loud prevents the common situation where three people leave believing someone else will follow up.

A short written recap sent the same day locks this in. It also creates a simple record that makes the next meeting faster, because the group can start by reviewing what was promised and what was delivered.

## Know when to cancel

Recurring meetings tend to outlive their purpose. A weekly check-in that made sense during a busy project can continue for months after the project ends. Leaders should review their standing meetings regularly and ask whether each one still earns its place on the calendar.

Canceling a meeting that is no longer needed is not a loss. It returns time to the people doing the work and signals that the team values results over routine.

Shorter default lengths help too. A meeting scheduled for twenty-five minutes instead of thirty, or fifty instead of sixty, gives people a few minutes to reset before their next commitment.

## Meetings as a leadership signal

How a leader runs meetings tells a team a great deal about what that leader values. Clear purpose shows respect for people's time. Careful preparation shows

respect for their judgment. Open discussion shows that their views matter, and clear follow-through shows that decisions will turn into action.

None of these practices are complicated. Applied consistently, they turn meetings from a drain on the week into one of the most useful tools a team has.

Read online at https://solomonawusah.com/awusah-on-leadership/issues/issue-02.html